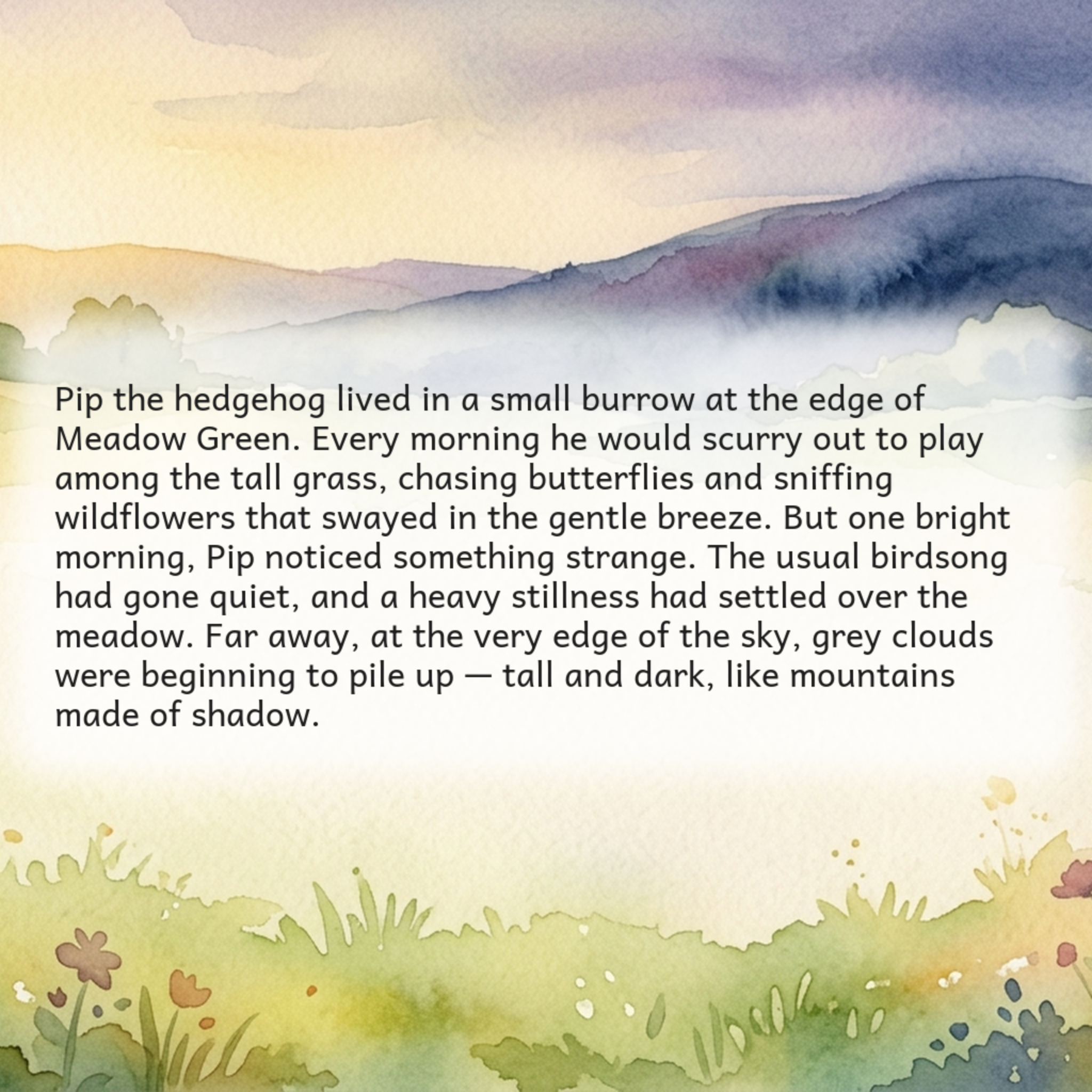




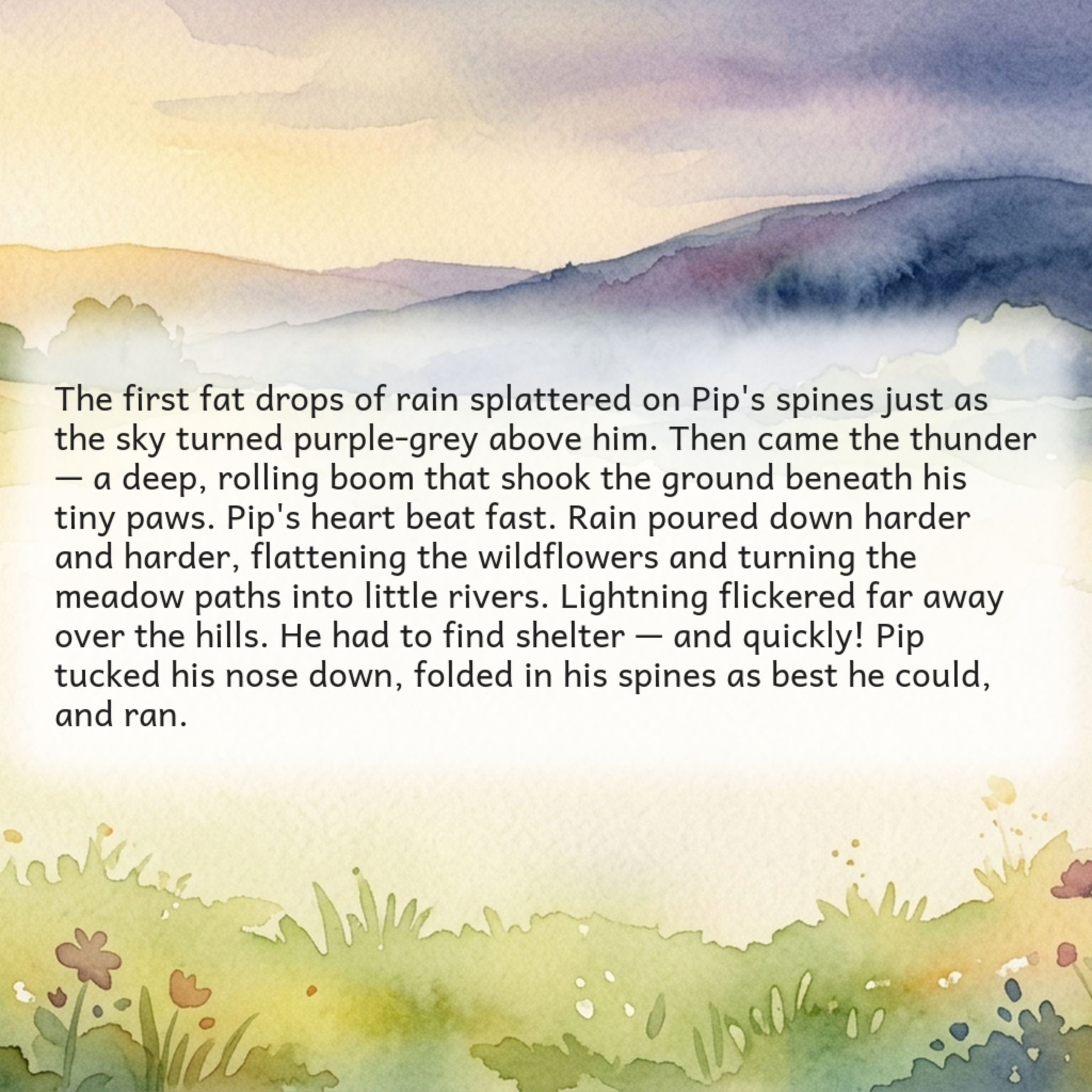
Pip and the Big Storm





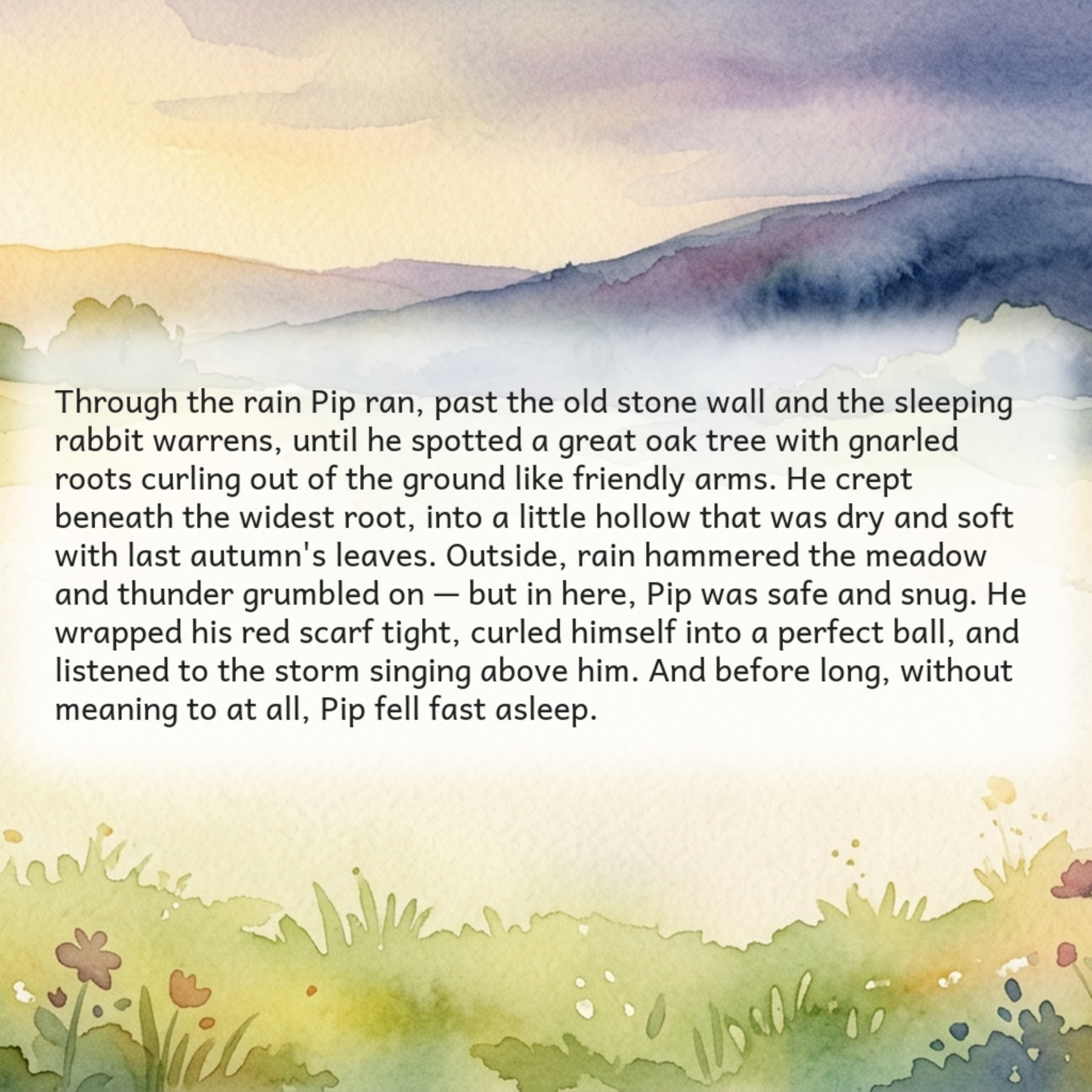
Pip the hedgehog lived in a small burrow at the edge of Meadow Green. Every morning he would scurry out to play among the tall grass, chasing butterflies and sniffing wildflowers that swayed in the gentle breeze. But one bright morning, Pip noticed something strange. The usual birdsong had gone quiet, and a heavy stillness had settled over the meadow. Far away, at the very edge of the sky, grey clouds were beginning to pile up — tall and dark, like mountains made of shadow.





The first fat drops of rain splattered on Pip's spines just as the sky turned purple-grey above him. Then came the thunder — a deep, rolling boom that shook the ground beneath his tiny paws. Pip's heart beat fast. Rain poured down harder and harder, flattening the wildflowers and turning the meadow paths into little rivers. Lightning flickered far away over the hills. He had to find shelter — and quickly! Pip tucked his nose down, folded in his spines as best he could, and ran.





Through the rain Pip ran, past the old stone wall and the sleeping rabbit warrens, until he spotted a great oak tree with gnarled roots curling out of the ground like friendly arms. He crept beneath the widest root, into a little hollow that was dry and soft with last autumn's leaves. Outside, rain hammered the meadow and thunder grumbled on — but in here, Pip was safe and snug. He wrapped his red scarf tight, curled himself into a perfect ball, and listened to the storm singing above him. And before long, without meaning to at all, Pip fell fast asleep.